

MUSTAPHA ABDULLAHI

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Machine Learning Systems, Reinforcement Learning, and Large Language Models

EDUCATION

Aalto University & Finnish Center of Artificial Intelligence (FCAI) April 2024 - Present
*PhD Artificial Intelligence (Advisor: **Prof. Bo Zhao**)* Espoo, Finland

Queen Mary University of London Sept. 2022 - Sept. 2023
MSc Artificial Intelligence [Computer Vision and Robotics] - Grade: 80% (Distinction) London, U.K.

Ahmadu Bello University Oct. 2015 - Nov. 2021
BEng Computer Engineering - CGPA: 4.90/5.00 (First-class) Zaria, Nigeria

EXPERIENCE

QuantumBlack AI Labs (McKinsey & Company) Oct. 2023 - Jan. 2024
Software Engineer Intern London, U.K.

- Developed a one-click CLI tool for effortless deployment of **Kedro** projects on **Databricks** Platform.

Large-Scale Data & Systems (LSDS), Imperial College London June 2023 - Aug. 2023
*Research Intern [Master's Thesis] (Advised by: **Prof. Bo Zhao** & **Prof. Peter Pietzuch**)* London, U.K.

- Evaluated tradeoffs among three distribution policies of MindSpore Distributed RL.

Huawei Jan. 2020 - Feb. 2020
Big Data/Cloud Intern Lagos, Nigeria

- Performed Relational Database migration using Cloud Data Migration Tool. Utilised Squoop to migrate data between Apache HDFS, Apache HBase, Apache Hive and MySQL database.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

- [1] Z. Tan, **M. Abdullahi**, T. Shi, H. Yuan, Z. Xu, C. Yu, B. Li, and B. Zhao, "EARL: Efficient Agentic Reinforcement Learning Systems for Large Language Models," *Workshop on Systems for Agentic AI (SAA), in conjunction with the ACM Symposium on Operating Systems Principles (SOSP)*, Oct. 2025.
- [2] L. J. Aliyu, U. S. Muhammad, B. Ismail, N. Muhammad, A. A. Wakili, S. M. Yimam, S. H. Muhammad, and **M. Abdullahi**, "Evaluating Deep Learning Models for African Wildlife Image Classification: From DenseNet to Vision Transformers," *Deep Learning Indaba*, Jul. 2025.
- [3] O. Fagbohun, N. P. Iduwe, **M. Abdullahi**, A. Ifaturoti, and O. Nwanna, "Beyond traditional assessment: Exploring the impact of large language models on grading practices," *Journal of Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning and Data Science*, vol. 2, no. 1, pp. 1–8, Feb. 2024.

SELECTED AWARDS

- Finnish Doctoral Program Network in Artificial Intelligence (AI-DOC) funded by Finnish Center of Artificial Intelligence (FCAI).** 2025-2028
- Finland Fellowship [for doctoral studies at Aalto University]** 2024
- Best Graduating Engineering Student in Nigeria, NSE (Nigerian Society of Engineers)** 2022
- 2023 Rhodes Scholarship Finalist [West Africa] - Dec. 2022**
- Google DeepMind Scholar** 2022-2023
- QuantumBlack (McKinsey Company)/Office of AI Scholar** 2022-2023
- Grand Prize Winner, Huawei ICT Competition Global Final - Cloud Track** 2020

VOLUNTEERING

Black in AI - Emerging Leaders in AI Grad Prep Program Dec. 2024 - Present
Academic Mentor Remote

Arewa Data Science Academy Feb. 2023 - Present
Lead Mentor, Deep Learning Fellowship (videos [🔗](#)) Nigeria, Remote